Repair the reasoning, not the person

Explain a distracting move and return the discussion to the question that needs evidence.

Suggested teaching time: 20 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None; learners identify what a question asks and whether a reply answers it.

Students will be able to

- Identify the question a speaker needs to answer.
- Explain how a reply avoids that question without relying on a label.
- Replace a distracting reply with a relevant, honest response.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; the instructor guide stays separate from student materials.
- Read all three scenarios and their model answers.
- Print the handout or display one activity at a time. Explain that all scenarios and figures are invented for reasoning practice.

Teaching sequence

3 min	**Find the unanswered question.** Learners complete the menu warm-up. Compare the evidence requested with the reply actually given.
7 min	**Repair the timetable reply.** Pairs write the main response. Check that they acknowledge missing results and propose evidence rather than inventing success.
5 min	**Discuss the reasoning move.** Use the discussion prompts and reveal the model answer. Accept plain descriptions of the mistake before optional labels.
5 min	**Try a new conversation.** Learners complete the crossing exit ticket independently. Use the assessment criteria to review the replacement reply.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / A question about the menu

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Fallacy: A recognizable mistake in how an argument supports its conclusion.

Personal attack: Dismissing a claim by attacking the person instead of addressing the relevant reasons.

Scenario

Invented scenario: Ari asks, 'Will the new lunch menu cost students more?' Bo replies, 'You complain about everything.' No prices for the old or new menu are provided.

Student output: Write two sentences identifying what remains unanswered and why the reply does not answer it.

1. Name the information Ari requested.

2. Explain what Bo discusses instead and why that does not supply the requested information.

Student success check: Does your explanation return to prices rather than decide whether Ari is a pleasant person?

Model answer

Ari wants to know whether students will pay more. Bo attacks Ari's behavior instead of comparing the old and new prices, so the cost question remains unanswered.

Why this meets the task: It identifies the missing information and explains the diversion without needing a fallacy label.

Main activity / Does the timetable help attendance?

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: Maya asks, 'What evidence shows the new timetable improves attendance?' Lee replies, 'You just hate change and want our school to fail.' No attendance results have been supplied.

Student output: Explain the unanswered question and the diversion, then write a two-sentence replacement reply.

1. State Maya's question in your own words.
2. Explain what Lee discusses instead and why that does not answer the question.
3. Rewrite Lee's reply: acknowledge the missing evidence and propose a relevant comparison. Do not invent a successful result.

Student success check: Have you addressed attendance rather than guessed Maya's motives? A label is optional; explain the error.

Model answer

Maya asks whether the timetable improves attendance. Lee attacks her motives instead of supplying attendance evidence. Better reply: “We have not yet shown that attendance improves. We should compare attendance under the new and old schedules while checking other changes, such as transport availability.”

Why this meets the task: It identifies the diversion and proposes relevant evidence without pretending the comparison has already been done.

Exit ticket / A question about a crossing

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: Sam asks, 'Would a new pedestrian crossing reduce near-misses here?' Jo replies, 'Either you support this crossing or you do not care about safety.' No near-miss records or comparisons have been supplied.

Student output: Write one explanation of the error and a two-sentence replacement reply.

1. State the safety question that needs evidence.
2. Explain why caring about safety does not require accepting this particular proposal.
3. Write a reply acknowledging the missing evidence and proposing a comparison that could assess the crossing.

Student success check: Do not confuse supporting an aim with accepting every proposal offered in its name.

Model answer

The question is whether this crossing would reduce near-misses. A person can care about safety and still ask whether the proposal works; Jo presents an unfair choice. Better reply: “We do not yet have evidence that this crossing reduces near-misses. We should compare near-miss records at similar locations with and without such crossings, checking traffic and pedestrian numbers.”

Why this meets the task: It explains the false choice in ordinary language and returns to evidence relevant to the claimed safety benefit.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The original question and the distracting reply are distinguished.
- The reasoning mistake is explained without treating a label or insult as proof.
- The replacement reply acknowledges the evidence limit and proposes relevant information.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

If Maya really dislikes change, would that settle the attendance question?

Listen for: No. Her attitude does not show whether the timetable improves attendance. Examine the relevant results.

Does a bad argument prove its conclusion is false?

Listen for: No. A conclusion could be true for better reasons. Identify what the offered argument fails to establish.

Common confusions

Naming a fallacy is enough. Explain which question went unanswered and how the reply departed from it.

Any comment about a source is a personal attack. Relevant expertise or access to evidence can matter. The error is using an irrelevant personal judgment in place of an answer.

Spotting a fallacy means the opposing policy must be wrong. The policy still needs evaluation with relevant evidence; an argumentative mistake does not settle its merits.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Give the frame: 'The question asks about ___. The reply talks about ___. We would need ___.' In the main task, expect attendance, Maya's motives, and relevant attendance comparisons.

More challenge: Ask learners to repair Jo's reply without using the words 'fallacy' or 'false choice'. A successful reply allows concern for safety alongside uncertainty about the crossing and identifies needed evidence.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=fallacies#workbench